LEAD COMBAT & SYSTEMS DESIGNER / 10 YEARS / AAA

JACOB LAVENDER

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10 YEARS	FORTNITE	BORDERLANDS 3	BORDERLANDS 2 VR
COMBAT & SYSTEMS DESIGN	80M+ PLAYERS, 8 SEASONS	22M+ UNITS SOLD	LEAD DESIGNER

Combat and systems designer across first-person shooters, third-person action, live service, and VR. Designed and built combat, player abilities, enemy AI, and 3Cs hands-on in Unreal Engine 5, and led a team of combat designers.

EXPERIENCE

2025 – PRESENT · PROBABLYMONSTERS

Lead Combat Designer · *added to Principal as the team grew*

Unannounced co-op action RPG · Third-person multiplayer, Unreal Engine 5

- **Team:** Led the combat team of designers and programmers; hired and mentored 4 designers.
- **Results:** Raised the external playtest score from 61 to 85 through combat changes.
- **Planning:** Owned the team's milestones, roadmap, and scope; ran combat design reviews.

Principal Combat Designer

- **3Cs:** Owned the core combat loop, camera, controls, lock-on, and game feel.
- **Abilities:** Built 32 player abilities in the Gameplay Ability System (GAS).
- **Enemy AI:** Built 20+ enemies on modular State Trees, paced by an attack-token system.
- **Systems:** Designed encounters, the economy, difficulty scaling, and meta progression.
- **Tuning:** Balanced combat with spreadsheet models, telemetry, and playtests.

2024 – 2025 · JAR OF SPARKS

Senior Combat Designer

Unannounced action-adventure · Third-person multiplayer, Unreal Engine 5. NetEase closed the studio.

- **Core loop:** Designed third-person shooting combined with hack-and-slash melee.
- **Abilities:** Built 20 abilities, 8 melee combos, and 3 ranged weapons in GAS.
- **3Cs:** Built a dynamic combat camera and modular controls shared across characters.

2023 – 2024 · PEOPLE CAN FLY

Senior Systems Designer

Unannounced hero extraction shooter · Third-person multiplayer, Unreal Engine 5. Project cancelled.

- **Spells:** Owned the core loop and a modular system for thousands of procedural spells.
- **Mods:** Built a mod system for movement, combat, and stealth; balanced it with telemetry.
- **3Cs:** Owned the sandbox camera, movement, and controls.
- **World:** Designed dynamic quests, encounters, and two overlapping playable worlds.
- **Hiring:** Mentored designers and built the design interview process.

2020 – 2023 · EPIC GAMES

Gameplay Designer III

Fortnite · 8 live seasons, Chapter 2 Season 6 through Chapter 4 Season 2

- **Features:** Shipped 11 weapons and items; built War Effort and Chrome phasing.
- **Melee:** Rebuilt the melee system on GAS for faster iteration and fewer bugs.
- **Live ops:** Owned features through live updates and tuned them with telemetry.
- **Onboarding:** Cut designer onboarding from 3 months to 3 weeks with new team docs.

2017 – 2020 · GEARBOX SOFTWARE

Systems Designer

Borderlands 3 + DLC, Tiny Tina's Wonderlands · Wonderlands in early development. Unreal Engine 4

- **Networking:** Built networked shooting, projectile, and vehicle systems.
- **DLC:** Designed encounters and content for the Bounty of Blood campaign.

Lead Designer · *promoted from Systems Designer in 2018*

Borderlands 2 VR + DLC, Penn & Teller VR · PlayStation VR and PC VR

- **Leadership:** Led a 20-person team and mentored 8 designers; owned the vision.
- **Platform:** Pitched and secured PlayStation exclusivity; owned first-party certification.

SKILLS

Design	Combat · Player abilities · Enemy AI · Encounters & bosses · 3Cs (camera, controls, character) · Game feel · Systems design · Progression & meta · Economy · Live service · Balancing · Level design · UX
Engine & scripting	Unreal Engine 5 · Blueprints · Gameplay Ability System (GAS) · State Trees · Unity · C# · Lua · C++ (reading)
Data & tools	Telemetry · Excel / Sheets models · Machinations · Playtesting · Jira · Perforce · Git · Figma
Leadership	Mentoring · Hiring · Design reviews · Roadmaps · Scoping · Pitching · Publisher & first-party relations

EDUCATION

2015 – 2017 · **SMU Guildhall** · Masters in Level Design · *Team project Mouse Playhouse VR shipped on Steam in 2016*

2011 – 2013 · **Texas Tech School of Medicine**

2007 – 2011 · **University of Arkansas** · Bachelor of Science in Biochemistry